

POL101-20

Kautilya, Machiavelli, and Weber

Monday focus: Weber and the modern state

Wednesday focus: short graded writing practice

Where We Are in the Course

1. We have defined politics through Heywood and refined its boundary through Sartori.
2. We used classical thinkers to ask why authority becomes necessary or legitimate.
3. This week shifts to statecraft and the modern state.
4. The midterm arc is now: definition → authority → state → sovereignty → political economy → nation.

Today's Core Objectives

- Use Kautilya and Machiavelli to discuss rule, power, and statecraft.
- Focus on Weber's definition of the modern state.
- Practice evidence-based discussion for midterm writing.

Quick Rewind: What We Already Built

1. **Aristotle:** politics begins in common life and the polis.
2. **Ibn Khaldun:** cooperation needs restraining authority.
3. **Hobbes:** insecurity makes sovereign authority necessary.
4. **Locke and Rousseau:** authority also needs consent, rights, or collective legitimacy.

Lets reflect:

**If human beings need authority, what makes
that authority organized, durable, and
recognizable as a state?**

Kautilya: Statecraft as Organized Capacity

1. Kautilya lists the elements of sovereignty: king, minister, country, fort, treasury, army, and friend.
2. Sovereignty is not only a **legal idea**; it also needs personnel, territory, resources, defense, and alliances.
3. A ruler's success depends on discipline, foresight, and the quality of the state's elements.
4. This fits Heywood's politics as the art of government and politics as power.

Kautilya: Peace, Policy, and Position

1. Peace is tied to security and the enjoyment of achieved results.
2. Policy, impolicy, fortune, and misfortune shape political position.
3. The ruler must read conditions: progress, deterioration, stagnation, enemy, friend, and neutral power.
4. This prepares us to think about the state as a strategic organization.

Machiavelli: Politics as Practical Truth

1. Machiavelli shifts from imagined politics to the “effectual truth” of political life.
2. He asks what a ruler must understand to maintain the state in difficult conditions.
3. The focus is not ideal virtue alone, but power, necessity, reputation, fear, and judgment.
4. This fits Heywood’s politics as power and the art of government.

Machiavelli: Loved, Feared, and Hated

1. The famous question is not simply “be feared.” It is how a ruler avoids disorder and hatred.
2. Fear may secure obedience, but hatred can endanger rule.
3. The key concept is political judgment: power must be used in ways that protect the state.
4. This becomes a bridge to Weber’s question: why do people obey rule?

From Kautilya and Machiavelli to Weber

1. Kautilya asks: what resources and elements make sovereignty effective?
2. Machiavelli asks: how is rule maintained under uncertainty?
3. Weber asks: what defines the modern state sociologically?
4. The shift is from ruler-centered statecraft to the modern state as an institution.

Why Weber Matters Now

1. Weber does not define the state by listing everything it does.
2. He defines the state by its specific means: legitimate physical force.
3. This moves us toward sovereignty, bureaucracy, and modern political order.
4. This is a key midterm concept.

Weber Starts by Narrowing Politics

1. Politics can mean many leadership activities in everyday language.
2. Weber narrows the focus to leadership or influence over a political organization: the state.
3. This connects to Sartori: we must not let politics become too broad to study carefully.
4. The question becomes: what is specific to the state?

Weber's Definition of the Modern State

The modern state is the human community that successfully claims a monopoly of legitimate physical violence within a particular territory.

Unpacking Weber's Definition

1. Human community: the state is a form of organized rule over people.
2. Territory: the claim operates within a bounded space.
3. Monopoly: other actors may use force only if the state permits it.
4. Legitimate: the force is treated as rightful, not merely as private violence.

Politics as Power in Weber

1. Politics means striving for a share of power or influence over the distribution of power.
2. Power can be pursued for other goals, or for its own prestige.
3. This directly connects Weber to Heywood's politics as power.
4. But Weber places power inside the state and its institutions.

The State Needs Acceptance

1. The state is a relationship in which people rule over other people.
2. Rule survives when those who are ruled accept or acquiesce in the authority claimed by rulers.
3. This brings us back to Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau: order alone is not the full story.
4. Weber asks why people treat authority as legitimate.

Weber's Three Grounds of Legitimate Rule

1. Traditional authority: obedience based on custom and the “eternal past.”
2. Charismatic authority: obedience based on devotion to an extraordinary person or leader.
3. Legal-rational authority: obedience based on law, rules, offices, and competence.
4. Real politics often mixes these types.

Authority Types: Examples

Type	Why it matters
1. Traditional: “This is how rule has always worked.”	1. Legitimacy can come from habit.
2. Charismatic: “People follow because they believe in this leader.”	2. Legitimacy can come from personal trust.
3. Legal-rational: “People follow the office, rule, or law.”	3. Legitimacy can come from procedure and institutions.

Modern State and Administration

1. Every ruling apparatus needs obedience and material resources.
2. Weber emphasizes administration: officials, staff, money, buildings, supplies, and equipment.
3. The modern state separates officials from personal ownership of the means of administration.
4. This is a major step from personal rule to institutional rule.

From Personal Rule to Institutional Rule

1. Kautilya lists the elements that make rule effective.
2. Machiavelli asks how rulers use judgment to maintain power.
3. Weber explains how modern states centralize legitimate force and administration.
4. Together, they help us see the state as power, organization, and legitimacy.

Professional Politicians

1. Weber distinguishes occasional, part-time, and full-time political activity.
2. Voting, attending meetings, or political speech can make someone an occasional politician.
3. Professional politicians live from or for political work.
4. This expands the idea of politics beyond rulers alone.

Class Poll 1

1. Is a state best defined by what it does or by the special authority it claims?
2. Which matters more for stable rule: force, law, or acceptance?
3. Can a rule be strong but not legitimate?
4. Can a rule be legitimate but weak?

Class Poll 2

1. Public transport regulation: Love, Fear, Hatred, Legitimacy?
2. Emergency evacuation order: force, legality, or public safety?
3. Driving license rule: public affairs, government, or legal-rational authority?
4. Border control: sovereignty, territory, or legitimate force?

Wednesday Activity Preview

1. You will choose one of two Weber-based prompts.
2. Write about 100 words in class.
3. Use one concept accurately and one short example.
4. Basic citation or page reference is encouraged.

So Far:

1. Heywood: definition of politics.
2. Sartori: boundary and placement of politics.
3. Classical thinkers: authority, consent, order, and legitimacy.
4. Kautilya, Machiavelli, Weber: statecraft, power, modern state, and legitimate authority.
5. Next: sovereignty, state-making, political economy, and nationhood.

Final Takeaway

Politics begins with shared life and disagreement.

Authority organizes rule.

The modern state claims legitimate force within territory.

Weber helps us name that shift.